

Palatial PLOTS

Between 2005-09, **Rs 93.5 crore** was spent on “upgradation” of houses of MPs and ministers. Since June 2009, eight ministers have renovated offices for Rs 78.41 lakh. Should they be put up in bungalows valued at over Rs 100 crore?



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Social Justice? Do we need the ministries for Panchayati Raj, rural development, urban development or steel, which was decontrolled in 1992? Is anyone looking at the big permanent cost of 20 white elephants which seem to serve no purpose beyond repetitious red-tapism?

Imagine if all this energy focussed on political optics were to be deployed on achieving results. Austerity should have meant re-looking at the way we create and run governments. Few countries in the world provide housing to ministers. Do our ministers need to live in bungalows worth over Rs 100 crore? Do they require such an expensive subsidy? It would be a better idea to create a special security multi-storied complex or better still simply pay ministers—even a crore of rupees per year—to let them fend for themselves. The objective—political and economic—is to make available resources for providing for the poor. Shouldn't austerity be a permanent goal where the Government

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Gross LEAKAGE

This year **Rs 1,24,000 crore** will be spent on rural development and poverty reduction. But do benefits reach the poor? Rajiv Gandhi said only 15 paise of a rupee reaches the poor. To deliver subsidised grains worth Re 1, government spends Rs 3.65. Why can't this be fixed?